

Herald — AGENTS.md

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Field	Value
Revision	2
Created	2026-05-15
Last modified	2026-05-19
Status	active
Status summary	added Spec-change rule per R-14 + Constitution §11.4.61
Issues	none
Issues summary	—
Fixed	R-14 partial
Fixed summary	spec-change rule propagated from CLAUDE.md to AGENTS.md
Continuation	I7 gate invariant pending in tests/ test_constitution_inheritance.sh

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Base agent rules: the Helix Constitution's AGENTS.md, provided by the **parent project's** constitution/ submodule (Herald does not carry its own copy). **READ IT FIRST.**

Discover the constitution by walking up parent directories until you find <ancestor>/constitution/Constitution.md, or by invoking the canonical helper <discovered>/find_constitution.sh. For standalone Herald work, clone the constitution alongside Herald:

```
git clone git@github.com:HelixDevelopment/  
    HelixConstitution.git \  
    $(dirname "$PWD")/constitution
```

The base file is authoritative for any topic not covered here. Herald-specific rules below extend them; they never weaken them.

Canonical: <https://github.com/HelixDevelopment/HelixConstitution>

Critical base rules restated (for agents that don't follow @imports)

- **No bluffing.** Every PASS carries positive evidence. Constitution §11.4 / §1.1.
- **Mutation-paired gates.** Every new gate has a paired mutation proving it catches regressions. Constitution §1.1.
- **No guessing language** (likely, probably, maybe, seems, appears) when reporting causes. Constitution §11.4.6.
- **Credentials never tracked.** .env git-ignored; runtime-load only. Constitution §11.4.10.
- **Never force-push.** Requires explicit per-session authorization.
- **Hardlinked backup before any destructive op.** Constitution §9.
- **60% RAM cap on heavy work.** Constitution §12.6.
- **Multi-upstream push.** Every commit fans out to all 4 hosts (GitHub + GitLab + GitFlic + GitVerse). Constitution §2.1.

Herald-specific agent rules

Project status (load-bearing for every task)

Herald is **pre-implementation**. As of 2026-05-15 the repo contains:

- README.md — mission, deployment model, constitution-inheritance contract, how to run.
- docs/specs/mvp/specification.md — MVP spec (section headings only; substantive content TBD).
- docs/guides/HERALD_CONSTITUTION.md — project-specific constitutional extensions.
- docs/guides/CONSTITUTION_INHERITANCE.md — operator/agent guide for the parent-discovery contract + the gate.
- upstreams/ — Herald's own mirror declarations (lowercase, §11.4.29-compliant).
- tests/test_constitution_inheritance.sh — inheritance gate (read-only assertions).
- tests/test_constitution_inheritance_meta.sh — paired mutation meta-test (§1.1).
- .gitignore tuned for Go (also ignores .DS_Store).

Herald **does not** ship a constitution/ submodule of its own — see docs/guides/CONSTITUTION_INHERITANCE.md for the rationale and the discovery mechanism.

There is no go.mod, no source code, and no build/lint tooling yet. When asked to "add a feature" or "fix" something, first disambiguate: **scaffold the project** (init the Go module, lay out packages) vs. **fill in the spec**? The answer determines whether you're writing Go or Markdown.

Never invent build/test commands. If a command is needed but the supporting file (go.mod, Makefile, CI config) isn't present, say so and confirm before scaffolding.

Inheritance gate (run before any commit that touches root docs or constitution/)

```
bash tests/test_constitution_inheritance.sh          # the gate
bash tests/test_constitution_inheritance_meta.sh    # paired
              mutation proof (§1.1)
```

Both MUST return 0. If either fails, fix at root cause per Constitution §11.4.4 — never silently accept the FAIL.

Spec-change rule (load-bearing — docs/specs/mvp/specification.md §"Specification documents")

Whenever docs/specs/mvp/specification.md or any file under docs/specs/ (any depth) is modified, **comprehensive planning and implementation of all changes is MANDATORY** — agents may not edit the spec in isolation. This rule does NOT apply to creating or renaming files; for those, ask the operator what to do with the new path. Treat every spec edit as a project-wide ripple, not a doc tweak.

This rule is mirrored in CLAUDE.md and in docs/guides/HERALD_CONSTITUTION.md §106. The inheritance gate's invariant **I7a–c** asserts the rule anchor (comprehensive planning and implementation) is present in all three files; a missing copy is a §1.1 propagation bluff and the gate FAILs.

Multi-host mirror convention (Herald's own upstreams)

upstreams/ contains one script per mirror host (GitHub, GitLab, GitFlic, GitVerse). Each script exports UPSTREAMABLE_REPOSITORY and is sourced, not executed. The Herald repo's origin remote is already fan-out (1 fetch URL + 4 push URLs) — a single git push origin <branch> propagates to all four hosts. Per-host naming intentionally matches each provider's brand capitalization; do not normalize.

Forbidden in this project

- **Re-adding a constitution/ submodule inside Herald.** Herald is consumed as a submodule of a parent project that already provides constitution/. A duplicate copy inside Herald is a deployment-model violation. The inheritance gate's invariant I6 enforces this — re-adding it will turn the gate red.
- Promoting Herald-specific values into the parent constitution (universal status must be EARNED; see Constitution §11.4 + §11.4.10).

- Modifying any file under the discovered constitution/ from Herald commits — the parent's constitution is read-only from Herald's perspective. Constitution changes go through the HelixConstitution repo directly.
- Adding new submodules without re-running `bash tests/test_constitution_inheritance.sh` afterward.